UNIT 1

Understanding Gender

definition • concepts • attitudes • construction • socialization • caste

1. Introduction: Definition of Gender

Gender = the socially & culturally constructed roles, behaviours, activities and attributes that a society considers "appropriate" for women, men and other gender identities. It is learnt, not born with, and it changes with time, place and culture.

Sex = BIOLOGICAL (born with) vs Gender = SOCIAL (learnt)

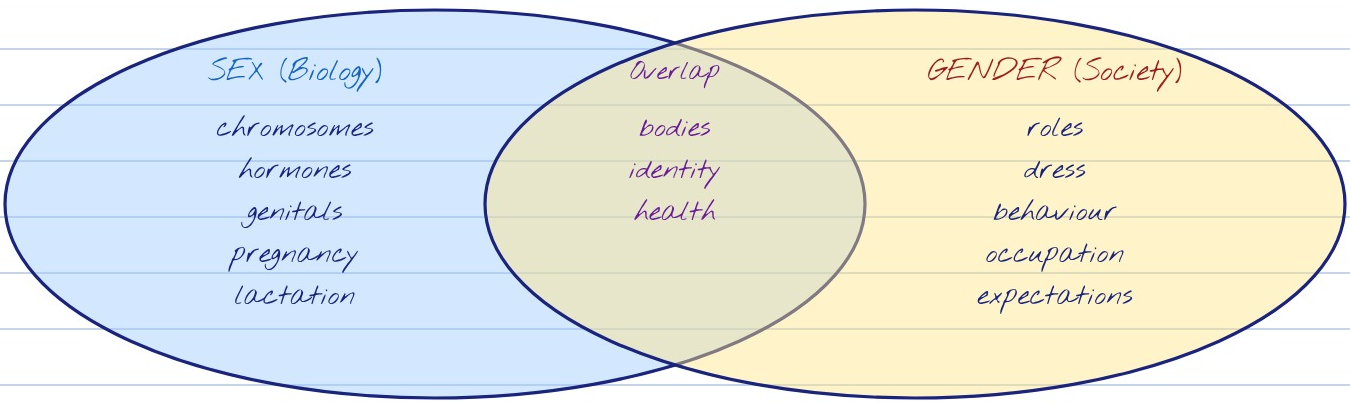
Q1. Define gender. How is it different from sex?

Ans. Sex refers to biological differences (chromosomes, hormones, reproductive organs). Gender refers to the social meanings attached to those differences.

› Sex is **natural, universal, fixed** (mostly); gender is **cultural, variable, changeable.**

› Example: only women can give birth (sex); cooking is "women's work" (gender).

Basis	SEX	GENDER
Origin	Biological, by birth	Social, learnt after birth
Nature	Fixed or universal	Varies by culture & time
Change	Cannot change easily	Can change (roles evolve)
Example	Women menstruate, men have beard	Girls = soft, boys = tough
Category	Male or Female or Intersex	Masculine or Feminine or Trans etc.



2. Basic Gender Concepts and Terminology

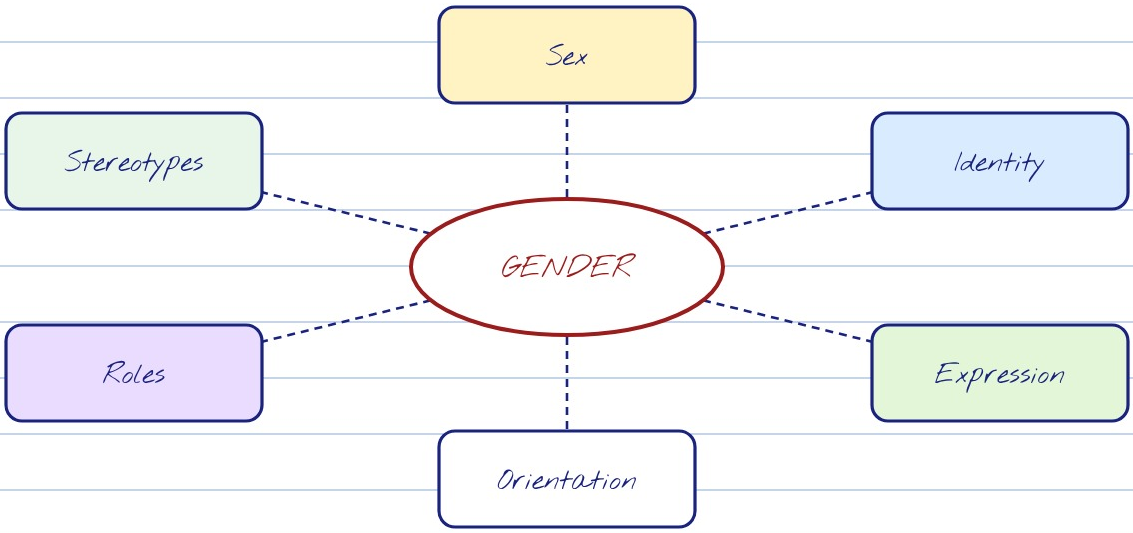
Q2. Explain the basic terms used in gender studies.

› **Sex** : biological classification at birth (male, female, intersex).

› **Gender** : social roles & expectations attached to sex.

› **Gender identity** : a person's inner sense of being a woman, man, both or neither.

- **Gender expression** : how one shows gender - dress, speech, mannerisms.
- **Sexual orientation** : to whom one is emotionally or physically attracted.
- **Gender role** : tasks & behaviour expected of each gender (cook, earn, care).
- **Gender stereotype** : fixed, over-simplified belief - "boys don't cry".
- **Patriarchy** : social system in which men hold power, authority and property.
- **Matriarchy or Matrilineal** : descent and inheritance through the mother (Khasi, Garo).
- **Gender discrimination** : unequal treatment on the ground of gender.
- **Gender equality** : equal rights, resources, opportunities & voice for all genders.
- **Gender equity** : fairness - giving each what they need to reach equality.
- **Transgender** : identity differs from the sex assigned at birth.
- **Gender sensitivity** : awareness of gender differences & inequalities and acting to remove them.



Remember (exam tip)

- Sex = Body, Gender identity = Mind, Expression = Dress, Behaviour, Orientation = Attraction.
- Equality = same for all; **Equity** = fair for each (different support, same outcome).

Q3. Distinguish between gender equality and gender equity.

Ans. Equality treats everyone identically; equity recognises different starting points and gives resources accordingly.

- Equality : same bicycle for all. Equity : bicycle that suits each rider's need.
- Aim of both : a society free of gender bias.

Q4. What is patriarchy? State its features.

Ans. A social order where men dominate women in family, work, law and religion.

- Male headship of family, inheritance through sons (patrilineal).
- Control over women's mobility, sexuality & labour.
- Preference for sons; dowry; the "honour" idea.

› Women are confined to the private (home) sphere, men to the public sphere.

3. Exploring Attitudes towards Gender

Attitudes are formed by family, school, peers, religion, media & law. They decide how we see "male" and "female".

Q5. How do attitudes towards gender develop?

Ans. Through repeated messages from childhood - "what a girl should or should not do".

› **Family** : toys (dolls for girls, cars for boys), chores, freedom of movement.

› **School** : textbooks show mother in kitchen, father at office, sports for boys.

› **Peers** : teasing of boys who cry, girls who are loud.

› **Media** : heroes = strong, heroines = beautiful & obedient.

› **Religion or custom** : rituals, fasting, who performs the last rites.



Q6. Give common gender-biased attitudes and the correct view.

Biased attitude	Correct or sensitive view
Boys are strong, they never cry	Emotions are human, not male or female
Girls are weak and need protection	Strength is individual; give girls skills & safety
Housework is women's duty	Care work is shared responsibility
Men are the breadwinners	Both can earn, both can care
Girls' education is a waste (she will marry)	Educated women uplift the whole family

Quick self-check questions

› Who does the cooking or cleaning in my house? Who takes decisions?

› Did I ever tell a boy "don't cry" or a girl "sit properly"?

› Recognising our own bias is the first step to becoming gender sensitive.

4. Construction of Gender

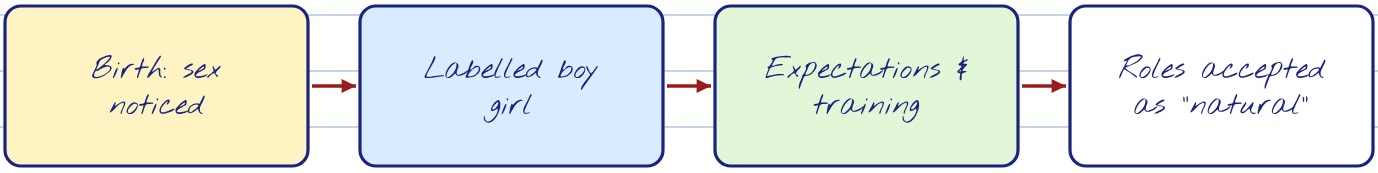
Social construction of gender : gender is not natural but "made" - through language, family, institutions and daily practice. Simone de Beauvoir : "One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman."

Q7. Explain how gender is socially constructed.

Ans. Society first notices a baby's sex and then assigns a full set of expectations.

› Naming, colour of clothes (pink or blue), toys, hairstyles, games.

- Division of tasks : girls help in kitchen, boys run errands outside.
- Language : "man of the house", "weaker sex", "tomboy" - words carry bias.
- Institutions (family, school, law, religion, market) **repeat** the pattern until it looks "natural".



Key points

- Gender is **learnt, performed and enforced** (rewards for conforming, punishment for deviating).
- Because it is constructed, it can be **de-constructed** and changed - this is the hope of gender studies.
- Gender intersects with caste, class, religion, region, disability.

Q8. What is the difference between biological determinism and social construction?

Biological determinism	Social construction
Roles follow from body (women nurture)	Roles follow from society & history
Differences are fixed	Differences are changeable
Used to justify inequality	Used to question inequality

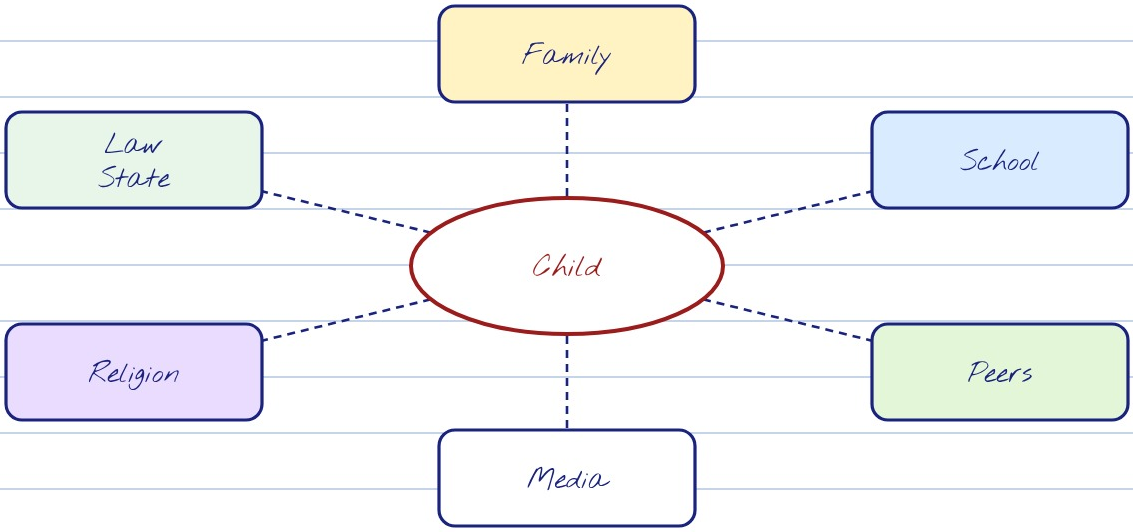
5. Socialization: Making Women, Making Men

Socialization = life-long process by which a person learns the values, norms, language and roles of his or her society. **Gender socialization** teaches a child how to be a "girl" or a "boy".

Q9. What is gender socialization? Name its agents.

Ans. It is the process of learning gender roles through interaction with agents of socialization.

- **Primary agent** : family (parents, siblings, grandparents).
- **Secondary agents** : school, peer group, religion, media, workplace, state.
- Methods : imitation, reward & punishment, instruction, role models.



Q10. Explain "Making Women, Making Men".

Ans. From birth, girls and boys are prepared for different futures.

- Girls : taught patience, modesty, obedience, care of others, household skills; their body is controlled ("don't go out after dark").
- Boys : taught courage, control, competition, earning; allowed freedom, anger, risk, outdoor play.
- Result : women become dependent, men become dominant - the **gender gap** is created.

Aspect	Girls are taught	Boys are taught
Behaviour	Be quiet, polite, adjust	Be bold, assertive, lead
Play	Dolls, kitchen set, skipping	Cars, cricket, guns
Work	Cook, clean, look after siblings	Run outside errands, earn
Emotion	Cry, show care	Hide feelings, be "tough"
Future	Marriage, motherhood	Career, provider

6. Preparing for Womanhood

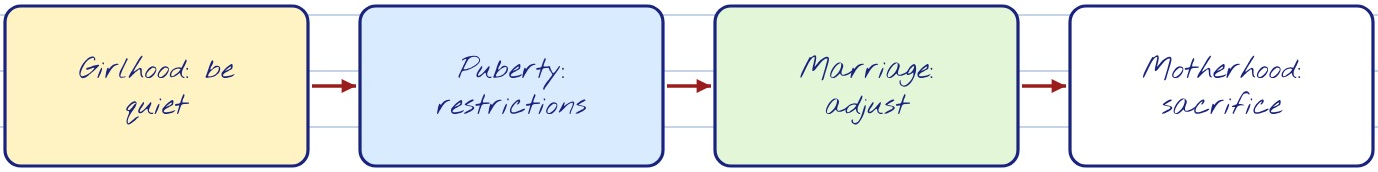
Theme (prescribed text) : how a girl is trained from childhood for the role of wife, daughter-in-law and mother - often at the cost of her education, mobility and dreams.

Q11. How is a girl child prepared for womanhood?

Ans. Through a series of lessons, spoken and unspoken, in the family and community.

- **Body discipline** : how to sit, walk, dress, laugh softly; menarche brings new restrictions & rituals.
- **Domestic training** : cooking, cleaning, sibling care - "practice for her husband's home".

- **Limited schooling** : early withdrawal, "girls are paraya dhan" (another's wealth).
- **Mobility control** : fear of "family honour", no night outings, accompanied travel.
- **Early marriage** & dowry thinking, identity as someone's daughter or wife or mother.



Impact on women

- Low self-esteem, lack of decision-making power, economic dependence.
- Health neglect (anaemia, early pregnancy), high drop-out of girls from school.
- Remedy : education, equal opportunity, laws (Prohibition of Child Marriage Act 2006), changing family attitudes.

7. Growing Up Male

Theme (prescribed text) : boys are also shaped - and pressed - by gender, "being a real man" has a heavy price.

Q12. How does a boy grow up as a male? What pressures does he face?

Ans. Boys learn that masculinity = power, control, no weakness.

- Encouraged to be aggressive, competitive & independent, "boys will be boys".
- Told "don't cry like a girl" - emotions suppressed -> anger, stress, silence.
- Freedom of space, time and money, no household duties -> later dependence on women's care.
- Pressure to earn, to protect, to dominate, fear of being teased as "weak".
- Peer groups reinforce **hyper-masculinity** (bullying, risk taking, harassment as "fun").

Privileges of boys	Costs of masculinity
Freedom, mobility, preference in education	Cannot show feelings, mental stress
Inheritance & decision power	Burden of being sole earner
Served at home	Violence, addiction, risk taking
Respect as the "head"	Isolation, fear of failure

Patriarchy hurts everyone - women are oppressed, men are pressed into narrow moulds.

Q13. Why is it important to include boys in gender discussions?

Ans. Equality cannot come unless men and boys change too.

- Sensitive boys become partners, not oppressors; share housework & care.
- Reduces violence, harassment and mental-health problems among men.

8. First Lessons in Caste

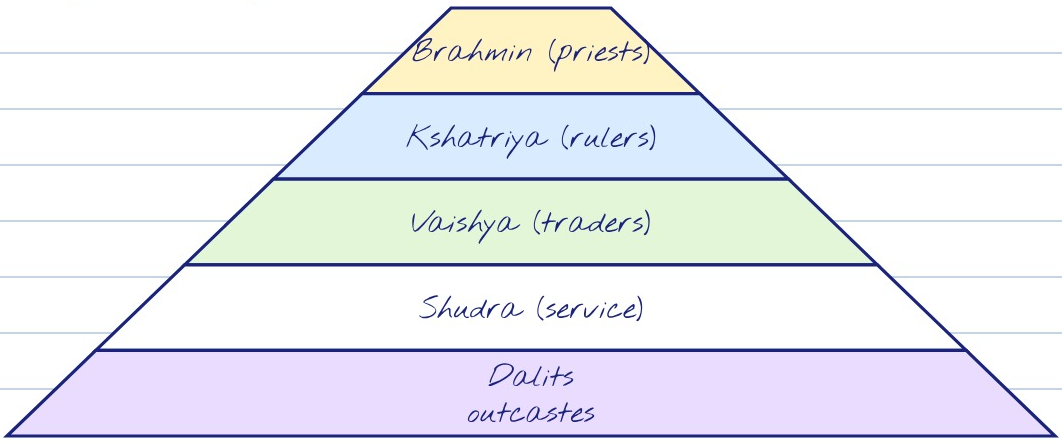
Theme (prescribed text) : a child meets caste early - in the village, school, temple, water source and the stories of the elders - and learns who is "high" and "low", who is "pure" and "impure".

Q14. What are the "first lessons in caste" learnt by a child?

Ans. Children absorb caste hierarchy through everyday life before they understand the word.

- Seating, food, water and games are divided on caste lines; "don't touch or don't eat with them".
- Separate settlements, wells, temples for Dalits; names and surnames reveal caste.
- Teachers & peers may humiliate lower-caste children; occupations are fixed by birth.
- Stories, proverbs & jokes teach superiority and inferiority.

Caste hierarchy (varna system)



Q15. How do caste and gender intersect?

Ans. Dalit women face **double (even triple) discrimination** - as women, as Dalits and as poor labourers.

- Upper-caste women : controlled sexuality to protect caste "purity" (endogamy, honour).
- Dalit women : sexual violence, manual scavenging, wage discrimination, denial of land.
- Hence, gender justice needs **intersectional** thinking (caste + class + gender).

Remedies or Constitutional safeguards

- Art. 14, 15, 16 (equality), Art. 17 (abolition of untouchability), Art. 21 (dignity).
- SC and ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act 1989; education, reservation; inter-caste dialogue.
- Social reformers : Jyotiba & Savitribai Phule, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, Periyar.

9. More Important Questions

Q16. What is a gender stereotype? Give examples and effects.

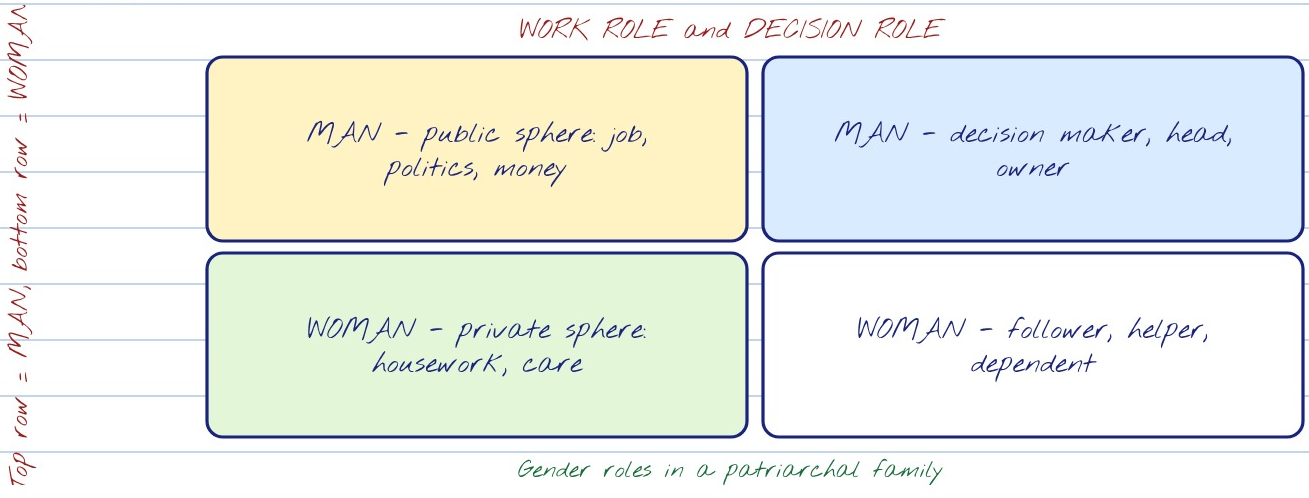
Ans. A fixed, generalised belief about how women and men should look, feel and behave.

- "Women are emotional, men are rational"; "girls are bad at maths"; "nursing is for women".
- Effects : limits choice of career, lowers confidence, justifies discrimination, hurts people who don't fit.
- Breaking stereotypes : role models, mixed-gender classrooms, balanced textbooks & media.

Stereotype about women	Stereotype about men
Gentle, emotional, dependent	Strong, rational, independent
Natural caregivers	Natural leaders or providers
Home-makers	Bread-winners
Should be modest	Should be dominant

Q17. Types of socialization - explain briefly.

- **Primary** : in early childhood, mainly in the family; language, basic values.
- **Secondary** : in school, peer group, workplace; wider norms.
- **Anticipatory** : learning for a future role (a girl rehearsing "bride" role).
- **Re-socialization** : unlearning old patterns, e.g. after marriage or a gender-training programme.



Gender roles in a patriarchal family

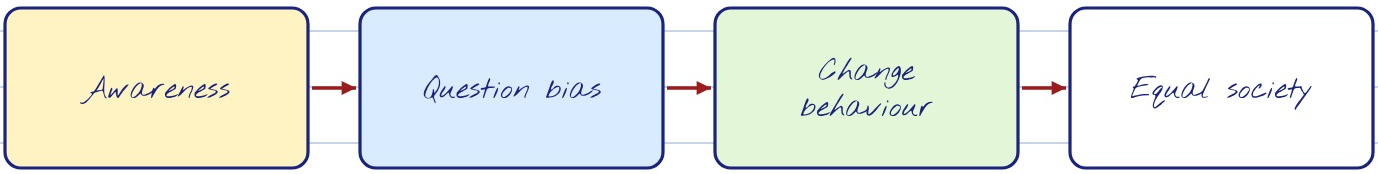
Q18. What is the role of education in gender sensitisation?

Ans. Education is the strongest tool to question and change gender norms.

- Gender-fair textbooks, co-education, equal sports & science opportunities for girls.
- Teachers trained to avoid bias, anti-harassment cells, life-skills & sex education.
- Educated girls : later marriage, healthier children, income, voice in decisions.

Q19. Why do we need gender sensitisation in colleges?

- Future engineers, managers & citizens must respect colleagues of all genders.
- Prevents ragging, eve-teasing, sexual harassment, builds a safe, inclusive campus.
- Improves teamwork and workplace culture.



Case study (practice)

- Rahul is mocked by friends for joining a dance class; his sister Rani is told to leave engineering as "girls should be teachers".
- Identify : stereotypes at work (boys don't dance, girls not for engineering).
- Suggest : support from parents/teachers, role models (male dancers, women engineers), equal opportunity.

10. Objective Practice (MCQs)

Q20. Choose the correct option

- 1. Gender is mainly : (a) biological **(b) social construct** (c) hormonal (d) fixed.
- 2. "One is not born, but becomes, a woman" was said by : (a) Mill **(b) Simone de Beauvoir** (c) Gandhi (d) Freud.
- 3. First & most important agent of socialization : **(a) family** (b) media (c) law (d) peers.
- 4. System in which men dominate : (a) matriarchy (b) democracy **(c) patriarchy** (d) feudalism.
- 5. Treating all alike (same support for all) = **equality**, fair, need-based support = **equity**.
- 6. Dalit women face : (a) single **(b) multiple discrimination** (c) none (d) only class bias.

11. Long Answer Questions (write in 10 marks format)

12. Short Answer Bank (Unit 1)

Q21. Write short notes

- **Gender role** : set of behaviours expected from a person because of being female or male.
- **Stereotype** : fixed over-simplified image, e.g. "women are emotional".
- **Intersex** : person born with sex characteristics that don't fit typical male or female.
- **Gender sensitisation** : training that increases awareness of gender bias & promotes equality.
- **Agents of socialization** : family, school, peers, media, religion.

Q22. Fill in the blanks or one-liners

- Gender is __ (socially constructed). Sex is __ (biological).
- "One is not born, but becomes, a woman" - ____ (Simone de Beauvoir).
- First agent of socialization = __ (family). System of male dominance = __ (patriarchy).

> Remember : Sex = born with, Gender = taught, Socialization = how it is taught.